



The Garamut "The message sender"

Ps Barry Reflections
from 'The WORD'!
For PRAYER,
PROCLAMATION &
PERSONAL PROGRESS

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THEME: THE UNITY IN GOD'S DIVERSITY

Recently in reading Matthew 4:18-22, I was impressed with the **diversity of peoples** that Jesus called to be his disciples and ultimately became his Apostles. Totally different people in temperament and expression - but all called to work **in harmony together**.

Matthew 4:18-22 (NIV) As Jesus was walking beside the Sea of Galilee, He saw two brothers, **Simon** called Peter and his brother **Andrew**. They were casting a net into the lake, for they were fishermen. **19** Come, follow me," Jesus said, "and I will send you out to fish for people." **20** At once they left their nets and followed Him. **21** Going on from there, He saw two other brothers, **James** son of Zebedee and his brother **John**. They were in a boat with their father Zebedee, preparing their nets. Jesus called them, **22** and immediately they left the boat and their father and followed Him.

Matthew 9:9 As Jesus went on from there, he saw a man named **Matthew** sitting at the tax collector's booth. "Follow me," he told him, and Matthew got up and followed him. NIV

"GOD'S TABLE IS AS DIVERSE AS THE WORLD HE CREATED."

God's grace is universal, embracing every tribe, tongue, and nation, and in that **human diversity** is a beautiful reflection of the Creator's design, and highlights how **diversity is meant to unite rather than divide**, celebrating the unique backgrounds that make up the human family.

GOD AS A GOD OF DIVERSITY HIGHLIGHTS THE BEAUTY OF DIFFERENCES IN CREATION AND IN PEOPLE, bringing these diverse parts together and desiring them to walk in unity and harmony."

"DIVERSITY IS NOT ABOUT HOW WE DIFFER; DIVERSITY IS ABOUT EMBRACING ONE ANOTHER'S UNIQUENESS." (Jesuit Resources Center)

- I noticed the different personalities of these men that Jesus called to follow him and impressed at the diversity of character, personalities, temperaments that they displayed and were known by.

THE CHARACTERISTICS OF JESUS' APOSTLES

PETER (SIMON PETER): **Impulsive, bold, and fiercely loyal, yet flawed.** He was a fisherman who transitioned from denying Jesus to becoming the foundational leader of the early church in Jerusalem & Rome.

JAMES THE GREATER: Known **for his fiery zeal**, he and his brother John were nicknamed the "**Sons of Thunder**". He was part of Jesus's innermost circle and was the first of the Apostles to be martyred. (by King Herod Agrippa I).

JOHN: (SON OF ZEBEDEE): Deeply sensitive, zealous, and loving. Also, a "**Son of Thunder**," he was initially prone to anger but matured into the "**apostle of love**." "The disciple whom Jesus loved," he wrote the Gospel of John and several Epistles. **He was theologically profound yet initially quick-tempered** and was the only Apostle traditionally believed to survive into old age, and John also cared for Mary after Jesus's death.

ANDREW: Peter's brother **and the first disciple called by Jesus.** Andrew was warm, endearing, and insightful. As Peter's brother, he had an easy-going personality and was known for constantly bringing others directly to Jesus. Also known for his evangelistic nature, he was a former follower of John the Baptist who quickly brought his brother Peter to meet Jesus.

PHILIP: Known for being practical, methodical, and reliable. He famously brought Nathanael (Bartholomew) to meet Jesus but struggled initially to grasp how to feed the five thousand. He often struggled to see beyond the immediate, obvious facts but was highly devoted to his duties.

BARTHOLOMEW (often identified as Nathanael): Described by Jesus as an "Israelite in whom there is no deceit." He had a reputation for being an earnest seeker of truth.

Bartholomew (Nathanael): Known for his uncompromising honesty and sincerity, he famously asked, "Can anything good come out of Nazareth?" before becoming a devout believer. His name Bartholomew is a family designation, meaning "son of Tolmai." Nathanael means "gift of God."

MATTHEW (Levi): A former tax collector who left his lucrative, despised profession to follow Jesus. He is the author of the Gospel of Matthew. Because he was a Roman collaborator, he was highly pragmatic, organized, had administrative ability and deeply appreciative of God's grace.

THOMAS ("Didymus"): Often remembered as "Doubting Thomas" due to his initial scepticism of Jesus's resurrection until seeing Him. He was deeply loyal and famously willing to die alongside Jesus. He was fiercely devoted.

JAMES THE LESS (Son of Alphaeus): One of the more obscure Apostles, known for operating quietly in the background. Known for his quiet, steadfast nature, he is distinct from James the brother of John and is often associated with James. He was just a key leader in the Jerusalem church. - Quiet, steady, and low-profile.

He possessed a consistent temperament, functioning as a reliable, behind-the-scenes supporter.

THADDAEUS (Jude/Judas, son of James): Known by a few different names, he is recognized for asking Jesus why He chose to reveal Himself only to the disciples and not the world. Thaddaeus (also called Judas or Lebbaeus): Gentle, tender-hearted, humble and inquisitive. He was marked by a quiet spirit and often asked thoughtful, profound questions – and is recorded in the Gospel of John as asking Jesus to explain why he would reveal himself only to his followers and not the world.

SIMON THE ZEALOT: Known for his intense political fervour and passion before becoming a follower of Christ.

A former member of the Zealots, a political faction dedicated to overthrowing Roman rule in Judea. His trait was his intense zeal, loyalty, and fierce patriotism. His fiery political intensity was later redirected into the gospel mission.

JUDAS ISCARIOT: A Gifted, calculating, and conflicted. He was highly trusted with the group's finances but was ultimately driven by a desire for money and worldly power. He betrayed Jesus for thirty pieces of silver, ultimately leading to his own tragic death.

MATTHIAS: Replaced Judas Iscariot. He is remembered for his humility steadfastness and faithfulness, serving quietly in the background.

Matthias: Chosen by the remaining eleven to replace Judas, he had been a witness to Jesus's ministry from the baptism of John until the ascension. His selection was determined by casting lots, making him the only Apostle not directly called by Jesus during his earthly life.

Throughout Christian tradition, he is depicted as a man of silent fidelity, possessing meek discretion, and dedicated to service over seeking the spotlight. He patiently waited in the upper room for the Holy Spirit at Pentecost alongside the rest of the early Church.

■ JESUS DID NOT CHOOSE THOSE WHO WERE ALL SIMILAR IN MAKE UP AND PERSONALITY - BUT THOSE WHO WERE DIVERSE.

■ THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN UNITY AND CONFORMITY.

★ The core difference is that unity is the coming together of diverse individuals around a shared purpose or vision, celebrating individuality. Conformity, however, is the pressure to surrender your individuality and adopt the exact same thoughts, actions, and beliefs as the group.

■ EVEN THOUGH BY GOD'S CALL WE TODAY FIND OURSELVES THRUST TOGETHER WITH THOSE WHO ARE DIFFERENT IN ETHNICITY, PERSONALITY, SKILLS & TEMPERAMENT BUT ALL WORKING TOGETHER IN HARMONY WITH EACH OTHER FOR HEALTH AND WELLBEING OF THE CHURCH - CHRIST'S BODY - Ephesians 4:15-16

★ GOD LOVES DIVERSITY – HE CREATED IT.

★ GOD LOVES EQUITY – HE PRACTICES IT.

★ GOD LOVES INCLUSION - HE COMMANDS IT. SO LET'S BE LIKE GOD.

Amen – Ps Barry